



▲ PROBING BILLS

The long bills of these curlew sandpipers have sensitive tips that allow them to feel for worms and other animals buried in the sand.

FAST FACTS

- On some Australian beaches, up to 10,000 sea turtles come ashore every night to lay their eggs during the breeding season.
- A sandy beach may conceal more than 2,000 buried shellfish such as cockles in every square yard (or meter) of sand.
- On rocky shores, many sea creatures survive the hours of low tide in pools of seawater among the rocks.

BEACH SCAVENGERS

Crabs are sea creatures that cannot breathe air, but some carry supplies of oxygen-rich water that allow them to survive on the beach at low tide. They include the shore crab and the tropical ghost crab, which feed mainly on dead animals washed up by the waves. Tropical fiddler crabs also live out of the water, and feed by extracting edible particles from beach sand.

HUNGRY SHOREBIRDS

All the worms, clams, and other burrowing animals that live beneath beaches and mudflats attract flocks of hungry shorebirds. Many of these birds are specially adapted with long legs and long bills for wading in the shallows and probing into deep sand. Others forage on rocky shores, and use their shorter, stouter bills to flip over rocks and seize small animals as they try to escape.



MANGROVE SWAMPS

Sheltered tropical shores become overgrown by mangrove trees, which are able to grow in salt water and waterlogged, airless mud. They form swamp forests that flood with seawater at high tide. Many animals live among their roots, including the mudskipper—an extraordinary fish that can survive out of water, and even climb the low branches of mangrove trees.

▼ TIME OUT

A ghost crab pauses on a South African beach before scuttling off in search of a meal.

